

Chapter 15 - Connection

But that shadow disappeared around the street corner in an instant. Ning Fuyi stood stunned for a moment, then lifted her legs and ran toward that direction.

"Yiyi! Where are you going?" Liu Wenzhu behind her looked around anxiously. Finally, unable to rest easy, she resolutely lifted her skirt and strode after Ning Fuyi.

The two ran through two streets one after the other before Ning Fuyi finally stopped. Her figure flashed as she hid behind bamboo baskets piled at a wall corner, secretly peering out.

"What are you looking at?" Liu Wenzhu stopped beside her quietly, whispering.

Ning Fuyi's eyes were fixed on the front. The white shadow from earlier was now surrounded by several burly men. One of them cursed in a language Ning Fuyi couldn't understand, then grabbed the thing by the scruff of its neck and lifted it up.

"Little thing, you sure can run! Run again, run again!" Another man held a long whip and lashed it several times, making the thing whimper pitifully. The sound was so miserable that it immediately made Liu Wenzhu's eyes red with tears, and she angrily gripped Ning Fuyi's wrist.

"Is that a little dog? Such a small dog - how can they bear to do this!" Liu Wenzhu was naturally soft-hearted and couldn't stand seeing weak creatures being bullied. She immediately wanted to rush forward, but Ning Fuyi grabbed her and stopped her.

"Wait." Ning Fuyi said. Although her voice was slightly trembling and myriad emotions stirred in her heart, she remained calm. "These men are from Dongyue¹. Their people have been traversing mountains and forests to hunt beasts since childhood. They've always been ruthless, and you can see their cultivation is all above Transformation Realm². If we try to force it, we definitely won't be their match."

Liu Wenzhu tightened her grip on Ning Fuyi's hand. She couldn't help but look at Ning Fuyi - the girl's profile looked as childish as usual, but somehow, when she said those words, she seemed mature and unfamiliar.

Like a girl who had always needed protection had grown up overnight.

Liu Wenzhu hesitated for a moment, then asked, "Yiyi, you seem to recognize it."

The little dog in front of them was only about an arm's length, covered in mud and blood stains. It looked like a broken doll, miserable to behold. At first glance, it was clearly just an ordinary mortal dog without any spiritual power. The only thing that could be called special was the black pattern on its tail, winding from the base all the way to the tip.

This type of animal was usually bred or caught in the cultivation world to serve as food for spirit beasts.

Ning Fuyi didn't speak. She didn't want to lie to Liu Wenzhu, but she also didn't know how to explain to her.

"Its name is Ping'an³," Ning Fuyi answered.

Ping'an, who wasn't safe at all, was also the last living thing that accompanied her in her previous life. Before this, although Ning Fuyi had cultivated the demonic path, she hadn't been completely corrupted by hatred and still retained some sense of good and evil in her heart.

Until that little white dog, who usually only knew how to eat and sleep, used its body barely half an arm's length to block a heavy sword condensed from the immortal power of hundreds of people. After that, she no longer cared about good and evil.

That night, she recklessly broke into the Six Great Sects⁴ alone. Thunder rolled across the Four Seas and Eight Wastelands⁵. Holding Ping'an's cold little body, she sat on Kunlun Tower⁶ for three days. For a full month afterward, lightning flashed and thunder roared within a thousand li⁷, with black miasma covering the sky and blocking the sun.

From then on, the Six Realms⁸ gave her a title: Heaven-Slaughtering Demon God⁹.

"Ping'an." Liu Wenzhu's voice broke Ning Fuyi's reminiscence. She thoughtfully repeated the name once. "So what should we do?"

"Follow them." Ning Fuyi tilted her chin.

Those men had already put the little dog into an iron cage and were casually carrying it back the way they came. Ning Fuyi and Liu Wenzhu quickly grabbed concealment talismans¹⁰, held their breath, and pressed against the wall, waiting for them to pass before revealing themselves and following.

The men stopped at the most bustling main street. The road here was wide enough for dozens of carriages to pass side by side. However, the street was now full of vendors on both sides, displaying various spiritual tools and spirit beasts, making even the wide road feel crowded.

Taking up the most space was the stall of those Dongyue men. They had more than ten black iron cages several people tall on the ground, containing many spirit beasts, but most were injured and looked weak, huddled in corners.

Occasionally people passed by to take a look, then shook their heads and walked away.

The burly leader placed the cage containing the little dog to one side, then cracked his whip viciously against those black iron cages. The harsh sound made the spirit beasts inside angry, and they began to stand up and pace in circles.

"Spirit beasts gather the spiritual energy of heaven and earth - they are pure beings. The Liu family also raises many spirit beasts, but I've never seen such a scene. They've gone too far." Liu Wenzhu had been pampered since childhood in a wealthy family and had a simple nature. Only now was she seeing the world's cruelty.

"It's always been this way. Human nature is like this." Ning Fuyi said softly, taking Liu Wenzhu's hand and stopping in front of those black iron cages as if passing by.

Seeing customers arrive, those Dongyue men immediately changed their expressions and greeted them with smiles: "You two young ladies don't have contracted spirit beasts yet, do you? We have mid-level spirit beasts freshly hunted from Tongchuan. Take a look - if you fancy any, we can negotiate the price."

Ning Fuyi looked around with an unchanged expression, even staring at a black phoenix for a while, then walked past the black iron cages and stopped beside the ordinary iron cage.

"Miss, that one isn't..." The Dongyue man was about to explain when Ning Fuyi interrupted him.

"This thing is somewhat special." Ning Fuyi widened her eyes, half-crouched, and waved at the little dog. The little dog whimpered once and hid in the depths of the cage.

These people had been wandering the world for many years. If she didn't make them feel they were getting a good deal, they would definitely become suspicious and wouldn't sell the little dog to her properly.

Several Dongyue men exchanged glances, all seeing contempt in each other's eyes. These two girls in front of them wore Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate robes - clearly disciples just starting their training, who didn't understand anything and were easy to deceive.

Especially the one in front of them, who looked to be barely of age and only had Mortal Realm cultivation. She actually mistook an ordinary dog for a spirit beast. If they could sell it to her at spirit beast prices, wouldn't that be a huge profit?

So the leader grinned obsequiously: "This is a young beast that hasn't formed yet. If the young lady wants it, just ten water jade¹¹."

"Ten water jade?" Liu Wenzhu beside them burst out angrily. "Even ordinary high-level spirit beasts only cost seven or eight water jade. Don't try to cheat people!"

"How could we be cheating?" The Dongyue man was clearly very experienced. "Young beasts that haven't formed yet could be any tier - it's naturally a gamble, a willing transaction. If the young lady is willing, take it. If not, let's not hurt our harmony."

Ning Fuyi suddenly stood up and took out a crystal-clear water jade from her chest, waving it in front of his eyes: "This young lady thinks this spirit beast is fairly special - one water jade. If you'll sell it, take it. If you won't sell it, it won't prevent others from having something better."

The Dongyue man seemed very troubled, struggling for a long time before finally nodding: "Fine, considering the fate between us two young ladies, take it."

With that, he opened the cage, pulled out the little dog that looked half-dead, and handed it toward Ning Fuyi.

Ning Fuyi closed her lips, her ears full of her own heartbeat. She carefully reached out to receive it, but suddenly a domineering voice came from behind, interrupting the Dongyue man's action.

The Dongyue man suddenly withdrew his hand and looked toward the voice with a fawning smile, his eyes lighting up.

Ning Fuyi had already recognized the voice and silently cursed her bad luck. She reached out to snatch the little white dog, but with her mere Mortal Realm cultivation, how could she match these people who licked blood from blade tips? After several dodges that seemed to push clouds and move mist, she hadn't even touched a dog's tail.

"Shopkeeper, wait. How much is this spirit beast?" Li Chao'an arrived with her two lackeys¹², wearing a golden silk wide-sleeved silk dress with a cloud brocade cloak over her shoulders. Her hair was arranged in four hanging buns as she asked crisply.

Seeing her clothing, the Dongyue man immediately knew she was wealthy. His attitude became more than twice as fawning as before, his face full of flesh piling into hills: "Miss, look - these are all top-quality mid-level spirit beasts. Just ten water jade can take one away!"

"Give me my spirit beast first - it won't delay you from serving other customers." Ning Fuyi frowned.

"Miss, please wait, please wait." That Dongyue man was truly cunning and treacherous. While speaking evasively, he made no move with his hands. Instead, he turned around, pretending to tend to the cages.

"These spirit beasts all look lifeless. They couldn't all be sickly, could they?" Li Chao'an looked at the black iron cages with disgust. At the same time, many people gathered around to watch the excitement, and the originally quiet stall suddenly became lively.

"How could that be? It's only because mid-level spirit beasts haven't learned to fast yet, and they haven't been fed today. They'll naturally become active once they see food." The Dongyue man whistled, and someone lifted the hemp cloth covering a nearby cage, pulling out two lively chickens and ducks.

"Wait, I don't want those." Li Chao'an looked at Ning Fuyi with malicious intent, her slender finger slowly moving toward the little dog in the Dongyue man's arms, curving into a smile. "I want to feed that one."

"Li Chao'an!" Liu Wenzhu glared angrily. "What are you doing?"

Li Chao'an ignored her. She winked at the troubled-looking Dongyue man and untied a money pouch from her waist. Opening the drawstring, she revealed it full of water jade: "If you feed it, all of these are yours."

Several gasps came from around them. The Dongyue man's eyes went straight, immediately nodding repeatedly, nearly drooling: "Yes, yes, yes, I'll feed it right away!"

At the same time, voices from the crowd urged the Dongyue man to hurry up. Under everyone's urging, the Dongyue man happily grabbed the little white dog by the scruff of its neck, making as if to throw it into the black iron cage, near a giant lion's mouth.

Liu Wenzhu anxiously looked for Ning Fuyi, but saw the girl standing calmly in place, her hands at her sides, gently tapping out a rhythm.

She had never seen Ning Fuyi like this before. Her eyes seemed devoid of reason, like a sword dipped in poison, radiating hatred and ruthlessness from every inch of her skin.

"Yiyi..." She hurriedly went to grab Ning Fuyi's ice-cold hands, but those hands suddenly stopped tapping. A few wisps of black smoke silently emerged from the ground, crawling like snakes up the black iron cage and soundlessly prying open the bronze lock.

At the same time, eight thousand li away, the melodious sound of a flute suddenly stopped. The woman in magnificent robes swayed for a moment, nearly falling to the ground.

She pressed her jade finger to her lips, and when she took it away, that tender hand was completely stained with striking red.

Footnotes:

¹ Dongyue (东岳) - People from the eastern regions, known for their beast-hunting skills

² Transformation Realm (化境) - The fifth level in the cultivation hierarchy

³ Ping'an (平安) - A name meaning "peace" or "safety"

⁴ Six Great Sects (六大门派) - Major cultivation organizations in this world

⁵ Four Seas and Eight Wastelands (四海八荒) - Expression meaning "everywhere in the world"

⁶ Kunlun Tower (昆仑塔) - A famous mystical location in Chinese mythology

⁷ Li (里) - Traditional Chinese distance unit; a thousand li is roughly 500 kilometers

⁸ Six Realms (六界) - The six domains of existence in Chinese mythology

⁹ Heaven-Slaughtering Demon God (诛天神魔) - Ning Fuyi's title from her previous life as a demon lord

¹⁰ Concealment talismans (隐身符) - Magical items that provide temporary invisibility

¹¹ Water jade (水玉) - A type of currency or valuable stone in the cultivation world

¹² Lackeys (烧饼面条) - Literally "pancake and noodles," derogatory nicknames for Li Chao'an's followers